

CODING AGENT PROMPT — v1.4: SKILL TREES, CURRENCY, DIFFICULTY SCALING

Send after v1.3. Three connected systems:

- **Part A** — a currency earned by winning
- **Part B** — a separate skill tree for each of the four pieces
- **Part C** — difficulty that rises level by level

Build in that order. Part C is what makes Parts A and B matter — without rising difficulty, upgrades just make the game easier and the tension dies.

PART A — OIL (the currency)

A1. What it is

The currency is **Oil**. It comes from the source material: oil is what consecrates, anoints and ordains. It is also what the lamp burns. Spending it on your servants is the same act as ordaining them.

Show it as a small vial icon with a number, in the persistent objective panel.

A2. Earning it

Oil is earned at the end of a level, from four sources:

Source	Oil
Level completed	10
Each house lit	4 each (max 12)
Lamp never hit	6
Each piece still alive at the end	2 each (max 8)
Verse checks passed on the first try	3 each

That last line is the important one. **The largest single source of Oil is knowing the passages.** A player who memorises them outpaces a player who leans on hints, and they will feel it. Make this line visible and prominent on the level-end screen.

Oil is never awarded for kills. This is deliberate and matches the win condition — the game does not reward clearing the board.

A3. Losing a level

A failed level still awards Oil for houses lit and verse checks passed. Losing must never leave the player with nothing, or a stuck player becomes a permanently stuck player.

A4. Persistence

Oil and all purchased skills persist across levels in the campaign save. Add to the save schema with a version bump and a migration path.

PART B — THE FOUR SKILL TREES

Each piece has its own tree. Oil is shared; the trees are not. The player must choose which servant to invest in, and cannot max all four in one campaign.

B1. Structure

Each tree has **three tiers of two skills each**. Six skills per piece, twenty-four total.

- Tier 1 costs 8 Oil, Tier 2 costs 16, Tier 3 costs 30.
- **Within a tier, the two skills are mutually exclusive.** Buying one permanently locks the other for that campaign. This is what makes the trees interesting — it is a set of forks, not a checklist.
- A tier unlocks only when the tier below it has been bought.

Total to fully upgrade one piece: 54 Oil. Roughly three good levels. Fully upgrading all four in one campaign should be impossible.

B2. The trees

All skill names and effects are drawn from the source teaching. Keep the names exactly as written.

PROTECTOR — Psalm 91

His teaching material: a knight in full armour, massive shield, stays close to the temple, bigger than the whole cathedral. The armour pieces come straight from the sessions.

Tier	Skill	Effect
1a	Shield of Faith	+3 max HP
1b	Belt of Truth	Verse checks where he defends get one fewer blank
2a	Breastplate of Righteousness	Takes 2 less damage from every failed check
2b	Feet Shod with the Gospel of Peace	Moves 2 squares instead of 1
3a	Under His Wings	His cover extends to all 8 adjacent squares, not 4
3b	Ten Thousand at Thy Right Hand	Any threat that ends its turn beside him loses 1 HP. He still cannot attack.

He never gains an attack stat at any tier. This is his identity. Do not add one.

DEFENDER — Psalm 109

His teaching material: winged, seeks from the tower, sees from far off what is coming, goes out and destroys.

Tier	Skill	Effect
1a	The Tower	Reveals one extra turn of forecast on the Coming board
1b	Wings as a Bat	+2 max HP
2a	Seeing From Far Off	Shows the exact tile each threat will move to next turn (a ghost marker)
2b	Set at His Right Hand	+3 attack
3a	Fourth Charge	4 strikes per level instead of 3
3b	Without Malice	If he ends a level with 0 avoidable strikes, refund 10 Oil

3b is the tree's conscience. It pays the player for the restraint the game is quietly measuring. Do not explain the connection — a player who works it out has understood the game.

The overuse system is unchanged by any skill. No skill reduces, resets or hides `avoidableStrikes`.

BINDER — Matthew 16:19

His teaching material: made of solid rock, long reaching arms, binds every single thing that has ever been bound.

Tier	Skill	Effect
1a	Solid Rock	+4 max HP
1b	Long Arms	Can lock an adjacent square instead of only his own
2a	Whatsoever Thou Shalt Bind	Locked squares also block movement diagonally through their corners
2b	Keys of the Kingdom	Unlocking is free — it no longer costs his action
3a	Bound in Heaven	One lock per level persists after he leaves the square
3b	Immovable	While locked, he takes no damage at all

1b is the tree's best purchase and should feel like it. The Binder's core frustration is that locking traps him; Long Arms is the first real answer to it.

LOOSER — Colossians 1:13

His teaching material: a massive shoal of red fish moving as one, the one who unravels, the one who releases.

Tier	Skill	Effect
1a	Shoal	+2 max HP (from 3 to 5 — a large proportional gain)
1b	Swift Waters	Moves 4 squares instead of 3
2a	The One Who Unravels	Release also removes 2 HP from an adjacent threat
2b	Delivered From Darkness	Survives a fatal hit once per level at 1 HP
3a	Translated Into the Kingdom	Once per level, teleport to any lit square
3b	Loosed on Earth	Adjacent friendly pieces gain +1 movement

B3. The UI

A **Servants** screen, reachable from the main menu and from the level-select screen.

- Four columns, one per piece, each showing its portrait, its passage, and its three tiers.
- Locked skills are visible but greyed, with their cost shown. **The player must be able to see what they are saving toward.**
- When a tier fork is bought, the unchosen skill visibly closes — a struck-through or shuttered state, not a disappearance. The player should feel what they gave up.
- Oil balance is always on screen.
- Confirm before spending. **This is the one place a confirmation dialogue is correct**, because the choice is permanent.

B4. Rules

- Skills apply immediately and permanently for the campaign.
- No respect, no refunds. The exception is the Defender's **Without Malice**, which is a reward, not a refund.
- **No skill may break determinism.** Every effect above is deterministic. If an implementation seems to need randomness, it has been misread — stop and ask.
- No skill grants the Protector an attack, adds a fifth passage, or touches the overuse counter.

PART C — DIFFICULTY SCALING

Six levels. Every level must be harder than the one before it, along several axes at once.

C1. The curve

Level	Turns	Tiers present	Threats	Forecast	New pressure
1	8	1	3	2 turns	—
2	8	1-2	4	2 turns	Poor soil on the best building squares
3	10	1-2	5	2 turns	Threats enter from two opposite edges
4	10	2-3	6	1 turn	Forecast window halves
5	12	2-3	7	1 turn	One house starts shrouded — needs two cornerstones to light
6	12	3-4	8	1 turn	Threats spawn on the turn they are forecast — no warning at all

C2. How difficulty rises

Do not simply add more enemies. Raise it along all of these:

1. **Tier composition.** Level 1 is all Shades. Level 6 is Depths and Abysses. A Tier 4 Abyss has 12 HP and 7 defence — the Binder at 5 binding faces a margin of -2 , which is 3 blanks and 2 tries. Late levels demand real recall, not hints.
2. **The forecast shortens.** Two turns of warning, then one, then none. The player's main advantage is withdrawn gradually.
3. **Geometry.** Single-edge spawns become two-edge, then spread. Good soil moves further from the houses.
4. **Turn budget vs work required.** Level 6 needs three cornerstones in twelve turns while under constant pressure.
5. **Never raise it with randomness.** Every level stays a fixed authored puzzle.

C3. Levels must stay winnable unupgraded

A player with zero skills must be able to complete every level. Skills widen the margin; they are never a gate.

Add a test: run each level under a scripted zero-skill solution and assert it completes. If a level cannot be solved without upgrades, the level is wrong.

C4. The six-check cap still applies

No level may allow more than 6 verse checks. `tools/validateLevels.ts` must continue to fail the build if any level can exceed it, including the new levels 2 through 6.

ACCEPTANCE

1. Oil is awarded on the level-end screen with each source itemised, and first-try verse passes are the most prominent line.
 2. A lost level still awards Oil for houses lit and checks passed.
 3. Each piece has 6 skills in 3 tiers; within a tier the two options are mutually exclusive and the unchosen one visibly closes.
 4. Locked skills are visible with their costs before purchase.
 5. Purchases require confirmation and cannot be undone.
 6. Oil and skills persist across levels, with a save version bump and migration.
 7. No skill gives the Protector an attack stat.
 8. No skill modifies `avoidableStrikes`.
 9. Every level is completable with zero skills — proven by test.
 10. `tools/validateLevels.ts` passes for all six levels.
 11. All determinism tests still pass. `Math.random()` still absent outside cosmetic effects.
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DO NOT

- Do not award Oil for kills.
- Do not let upgrades outrun the difficulty curve. If playtesting shows level 6 is easier than level 3 with a maxed piece, cut the skill's numbers, not the level.
- Do not add a respec option.
- Do not make any level require upgrades to win.
- Do not add a fifth passage or a fifth piece.
- Do not explain what the Defender's **Without Malice** skill is really measuring.
- If any of this seems wrong, stop and ask rather than improvising.